



MONTHLY UPDATE

Lesotho: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-25 • 22 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • TECHNOLOGY • CAPACITY • INCLUSION • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Two things were approved and four institutions were stood up. Project Kobong was [approved and launched at a ceremony hosted by the US Embassy on 31 July 2026](#), and on 29 July MICSTI and the Lesotho Communications Authority [launched an interim national CSIRT and the inaugural National Cybersecurity Forum](#), alongside a first Chief Information Security Officer across government and a Security Operations Centre being stood up.

On the payments side, [Tsetela](#) opened wallet-based investment on 22 July, and Econet Telecom Lesotho and UNDP [signed a memorandum on 28 July](#) that names a National AI Academy. Drafting of a National Data Value Creation Blueprint [opened at a consultative workshop on 14–15 July](#), and in the window's closing week a [six-ministry workshop in Maseru](#) began drafting a [national data-centre implementation roadmap](#) with UN and World Bank support.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The month's policy work is a strategy being drafted rather than one adopted. A [National AI Strategy is being written at the same five-day Maseru workshop as the data-centre blueprint, opened on 17 August by the communications ministry with the United Nations in Lesotho](#), and is distinct from the National AI Policy signed in June. The deputy prime minister's keynote asked for Lesotho's existing capabilities, safeguards, infrastructure, policy and human capacity to be settled before AI investment is scaled. No publication date, custodian, scope or cost is stated, and nothing beyond the workshop is on the record.

Legislation and regulation

No instrument was made, gazetted or brought into force in this window. [Reporting of the CSIRT launch](#) discloses that the Computer Crime and Cybersecurity Bill has been split into a Cybercrime Bill and a Cybersecurity Bill, both awaiting National Assembly approval, and the ministerial reference to a national cybersecurity strategy that the wiki does not hold.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The state opened a channel for hearing what its digital services are actually like to use: a [public survey opened on 9 August covering access, usability, trust and skills gaps across online applications, digital payments and health and education platforms](#), run with the United Nations development programme as part of a digital readiness assessment. No closing date, sample target or commitment to publish the results is stated, so what it will settle is not yet knowable.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The development-partner support named at the Blueprint workshop carries no amount; no appropriation, disbursement or training figure was published in the window.

ICT Infrastructure

Data Storage

The Kobong Project was approved and launched on 31 July 2026 at a ceremony hosted by the US Embassy in Maseru, attended by the ministers of energy and mining, of information and communications, and of environment and forestry. [Convalt Energy's chief executive stated capital investment of about US\\$6.2 billion](#); the government figure for the project was restated as M100 billion against the M98 billion [announced with the binding agreement of 4 June](#), with the dollar figure unchanged. The US Chargé d'Affaires described the investment as trade over aid. Construction remains targeted for 2029 and the agreement remains conditional on feasibility, financing, permitting and definitive agreements.

Separately, and with no stated relationship to Kobong, the state began drafting a data-centre policy of its own. A [five-day, six-ministry workshop ran in Maseru from 17 to 21 August toward a draft data-centre implementation roadmap](#), coordinated by the UN Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies with the Resident Coordinator's Office and joined by UNESCO, the ITU, UNICEF, the OECD, the World Bank Group and UNDP. It covers data governance, skills, compute, energy, cooling, financing and implementation choices, and builds on the artificial-intelligence, data-management and broadband policies the government validated in draft in January 2025. The workshop [opened on 17 August with the deputy prime minister's keynote, drafting a National AI Strategy alongside the blueprint](#).

Cybersecurity

The [interim Lesotho National Computer Security Incident Response Team](#) and the inaugural National Cybersecurity Forum were launched in Maseru on 29 July 2026. The forum is described by the Lesotho Communications Authority as a standing collaboration across government, industry, regulators, financial institutions and telecommunications providers. The response team is thus operating ahead of its enabling statute — the Cybercrime and Cybersecurity Bills it would sit under remain before the National Assembly — and on no published timetable. The ministry also reported a first Chief Information Security Officer appointed across government and a national Security Operations Centre being stood up.

DPI

Digital Payments and Fintech

Vodacom Financial Services and STANLIB Lesotho launched [Tsetela](#) at the Mpilo Boutique Hotel in Maseru on Wednesday 22 July 2026 — the date fixed by [Vodacom Lesotho's own announcement of that day](#), against two press accounts that dated it relatively. Eligible individual M-Pesa customers can invest from M50 and Mokhatlo group-savings customers from M300, with balances, daily interest and withdrawals over USSD on *200#. STANLIB Lesotho is licensed by the Central Bank of Lesotho, with segregated investor funds, annual audit and an independent trustee.

Standard Bank's [extension of CIPS renminbi settlement](#) beyond South Africa, reported on 27 July, names Lesotho as one of five added markets.

Sectoral management information systems

UNICEF and the Global Partnership for Education [announced support on 23 July](#) for a Foundational Literacy and Numeracy Dashboard consolidating Grades 1–3 performance, with tablets for principals in 300 project schools and solar power in 25 cluster learning spaces.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

MICSTI hosted the [first national stakeholder consultative workshop on a National Data Value Creation Blueprint](#) in Maseru on 14–15 July 2026, opened by Principal Secretary Kanono Ramashamole and supported by Smart Africa, the African Union and the German Embassy. A Smart Africa representative is reported saying Lesotho had been selected to participate in the programme alongside Senegal and Kenya; that account of a spokesperson's remarks is the only evidence held for the membership, and no Smart Africa programme document naming Lesotho is on file.

At the CSIRT launch the ministry also stated a plan to move ICT services out of the civil service into a separate agency, for which no enabling instrument or date was given.

Technology

AI

The same Econet-UNDP memorandum establishes a National AI Academy, with nothing naming a timetable, governance structure, curriculum or host institution for it. Econet Group separately states an agreement with NVIDIA for African AI compute capacity; nothing on file corroborates it and no capacity figure or siting is given.

At the UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva, MICSTI Principal Secretary Kanono Ramashamole [argued that developing nations must be co-creators rather than only consumers of AI](#), naming fragmented data and weak governance as obstacles.

A [CIPIT paper published on 1 July](#) reads Lesotho's AI strategy against the African Union Continental AI Strategy and other national strategies, and finds intellectual property acknowledged as an enabler while training-data licensing, authorship of AI-generated works and infringement are engaged only to a limited extent.

Innovation ecosystem

Econet Telecom Lesotho and UNDP [signed a memorandum of understanding](#) at the Mpilo Boutique Hotel on Tuesday 28 July 2026, signed by ETL chief executive Dennis Plaatjies and UNDP deputy resident representative Dr Taye Amssalu, renewing a partnership first signed in 2020 and amended in 2022. It runs across digital transformation, connectivity and AI; innovation and skills, including a University Innovation Pod; and MSME digital entrepreneurship. No amount, term or deliverable is stated in any account held.

Capacity

Training and skills

MICSTI reported [digital-literacy training running across all ten districts](#) at the CSIRT launch on 29 July, with no participant numbers published.

Inclusion

Access to services

At Geneva on 9 July the ministry gave its own measure of the access problem — [100% broadband coverage against about 50% regular internet use](#), which it attributed to affordability.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The [US Embassy stated](#) at the Kobong ceremony that it has facilitated US\$7.3bn of commercial partnerships in Lesotho over the previous eighteen months.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	2026-08-25
CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/LSO/LSO-monthly.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/LSO/LSO-monthly-2026-08-25.pdf
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